blocks. But, he observed, the poverty he saw everywhere, ‘resulted from the undeveloped economy’.

From 19 July to 5 August 1947, he led an FDJ delegation to the Soviet Union to visit factories, schools and sanatoriums, treating Soviet soldiers wounded in the fight against Hitler. The journey, dubbed by the media as a ‘Flight for Peace to the East’, saw Honecker standing before rows of sick beds, and speaking of his gratitude ‘for all that the Soviet people have done, for the trust placed in us.’19

The group – which included his FDJ deputy Edith Baumann – journeyed by air to Stalingrad and by train to Leningrad. In an interview with Neues Deutschland at the ‘Astoria’, the hotel earmarked for Hitler’s headquarters before his failed assault on the city, he spoke of meeting German prisoners of war: ‘they are not used in heavy labour,’ he assured, ‘and have the same food rations of the Soviet Army’.20 He went to pains to explain that Russians did not dislike Germans, ‘but hated German fascism, which destroyed their homeland so terribly. They know that the Soviet youth are sympathetic to the progressive German youth and will help them to eliminate the last remnants of fascism in Germany.’

In Moscow, away from official duties, he found time to join a procession of people filing silently past Lenin’s dimly lit tomb in Red Square. In deference to this magnetic figure who had loomed over him since childhood, Honecker took off his hat and walked slowly in silence. He didn’t kiss or touch the glass encasing Lenin’s corpse, nor lay flowers … but just stared.

During this trip, he nursed any grief he may have felt for Charlotte by embarking on a relationship with his deputy Edith Baumann, who was three years older but no dazzling bauble. Surviving photographs show a short, stocky, frumpy, plain-looking woman. According to friend Gerhard Schürer, what he felt for her was probably not physical attraction: ‘I was always a bit surprised,’ he stated, ‘because politically they were an experienced couple. He was a handsome man with a good physique, whereas she was an elderly comrade,’ a lady with a clear sense of morality. ‘I was in need of support at the time,’ Honecker said of Edith in 1990. ‘We often sat together, including at her home in Mühlenbeck.’ It is possible, that perhaps, Honecker sought